space remaining in the billing envelope, after inclusion of the monthly bill and any required legal notices, for inclusion of other materials up to such total envelope weight as would not result in any additional postage cost." *Ibid.*

In an effort to apportion this "extra space" between appellant and its customers, the Commission permitted TURN to use the "extra space" four times a year for the next two years. During these months, appellant may use any space not used by TURN, and it may include additional materials if it pays any extra postage. The Commission found that TURN has represented the interests of "a significant group" of appellant's residential customers, *id.*, at A–15, and has aided the Commission in performing its regulatory function, *id.*, at A–49 to A–50. Consequently, the Commission determined that ratepayers would benefit from permitting TURN to use the extra space in the billing envelopes to raise funds and to communicate with ratepayers: "Our goal . . . is to change the present system to one which uses the extra space more efficiently for the ratepayers' benefit. It is reasonable to assume that the ratepayers will benefit more from exposure to a variety of views than they will from only that of PG&E." *Id.*, at A–17. The Commission concluded that appellant could have no interest in excluding TURN's message from the billing envelope since appellant does not own the space that message would fill. *Id.*, at A–23.[4] The Commis-

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ratepayer funds, and is not an intended or necessary item of rate base, and that the only alternative treatment would unjustly enrich PG&E and simultaneously deprive the ratepayers of the value of that space, we concluded that the extra space in the billing envelope 'is properly considered as ratepayer property.'" *Id.*, at A–3.

[4] Commissioners Bagley and Calvo dissented from the Commission's decision to grant TURN access to the billing envelopes. Commissioner Bagley argued that the Commission's order had potentially sweeping consequences for various kinds of property interests:

"The face of every utility-owned dam, the side of every building, the surface of every gas holder rising above our cities, and the bumpers of every utility vehicle—to name just a few relevant examples—have 'excess space'

sion placed no limitations on what TURN or appellant could say in the envelope, except that TURN is required to state that its messages are not those of appellant. *Id.*, at A–17 to A–18. The Commission reserved the right to grant other groups access to the envelopes in the future.[5] *Ibid.*

Appellant appealed the Commission's order to the California Supreme Court, arguing that it has a First Amendment right not to help spread a message with which it disagrees, see *Wooley* v. *Maynard*, 430 U. S. 705 (1977), and that the Commission's order infringes that right. The California Supreme Court denied discretionary review. We noted probable jurisdiction, 470 U. S. 1083 (1985), and now reverse.

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and 'economic advertising value.' Some utility corporations place bumperstrip messages on their vehicles. Buses and trucks regularly carry advertising messages. In the words of the majority at page 23 of the decision, 'It is reasonable to assume that the ratepayers will benefit from exposure to a variety of views. . . .' Is it the postulate of this Commission, flowing from the decision's stated premise . . . that ratepayers would benefit from exposure to some particular socially desirable message from some ratepayer group making use of any or all such areas of excess valuable space?" *Id.*, at A–40.

Commissioner Bagley also argued that the Commission's decision would require the Commission to make forbidden content-based distinctions in order to allocate the extra space among competing speakers. *Id.*, at A–41. Commissioner Calvo contended, first, that the order infringed appellant's First Amendment rights, and, second, that it was unnecessary because "TURN has other opportunities to reach its natural audience." *Id.*, at A–56. Commissioner Calvo noted that the Commission often awarded TURN and similar groups fees for their participation in ratemaking proceedings, funds that presumably could finance separate mailings. *Ibid.*

[5] The Commission has already *denied* access to at least one group based on the content of its speech. The Commission denied the application of a taxpayer group—the Committee of More than One Million Taxpayers to Save Proposition 13—on the ground that that group neither wished to participate in Commission proceedings nor alleged that its use of the billing envelope space would improve consumer participation in those proceedings. *Id.*, at A–157 to A–164. The record does not reveal whether any other groups have sought access to the billing envelopes.

II

The constitutional guarantee of free speech "serves significant societal interests" wholly apart from the speaker's interest in self-expression. *First National Bank of Boston* v. *Bellotti*, 435 U. S. 765, 776 (1978). By protecting those who wish to enter the marketplace of ideas from government attack, the First Amendment protects the public's interest in receiving information. See *Thornhill* v. *Alabama*, 310 U. S. 88, 102 (1940); *Saxbe* v. *Washington Post Co.*, 417 U. S. 843, 863–864 (1974) (POWELL, J., dissenting). The identity of the speaker is not decisive in determining whether speech is protected. Corporations and other associations, like individuals, contribute to the "discussion, debate, and the dissemination of information and ideas" that the First Amendment seeks to foster. *First National Bank of Boston* v. *Bellotti*, *supra*, at 783 (citations omitted). Thus, in *Bellotti*, we invalidated a state prohibition aimed at speech by corporations that sought to influence the outcome of a state referendum. 435 U. S., at 795. Similarly, in *Consolidated Edison Co.* v. *Public Service Comm'n of N. Y.*, 447 U. S. 530, 544 (1980), we invalidated a state order prohibiting a privately owned utility company from discussing controversial political issues in its billing envelopes. In both cases, the critical considerations were that the State sought to abridge speech that the First Amendment is designed to protect, and that such prohibitions limited the range of information and ideas to which the public is exposed. *First National Bank of Boston* v. *Bellotti*, *supra*, at 776–778, 781–783; *Consolidated Edison Co.* v. *Public Service Comm'n of N. Y.*, *supra*, at 533–535.

There is no doubt that under these principles appellant's newsletter *Progress* receives the full protection of the First Amendment. *Lovell* v. *Griffin*, 303 U. S. 444, 452 (1938). In appearance no different from a small newspaper, *Progress*' contents range from energy-saving tips to stories about wildlife conservation, and from billing information to recipes. App. to Juris. Statement A–183 to A–190. *Progress* thus